

"The Mask of Agamemnon"

This astonishing burial mask was found at Mycenae in Greece by the archaeologist Heinrich Schliemann in 1876. He named the mask after the leader of the Greek troops during the Trojan War. It is part of a collection of royal treasure dating from c. 1600 BCE.

Over the centuries, written histories, like the folktales that preceded them, have been shaped by the values of the times in which they were recorded.

THE EPIC TRADITION

Old stories told in traditional ways connect powerfully with the listeners, as they are rooted in local landscape, history, and folklore. *Beowulf* is an English epic poem of the 10th century CE. The story concerns the struggle between forces of good and evil. In Cyprus, shepherds still tell stories about one-eyed giants, horned gods, and Bacchanalian feasts in nearby river beds.



BEOWULF MANUSCRIPT

MODERN MYTH AND HISTORY

Kathakali stories of Hindu myth, using dance and masks, costumes and music to accompany oral texts, are still performed today. The *Mahabharata* and the *Ramayana*, tales about the various Hindu divinities 145 >>, are told to people who may be unable to read, in the same way that the stories of Homer were told in ancient Greece.



KATHAKALI DANCER

word for word, but rewritten to express Thucydides's personal opinion. One famous example is the speech made by Pericles (see p.100), in which the city of Athens and all its achievements are praised in a funeral oration for those who had died in the war.

Despite their shortcomings—the inaccuracies of Herodotus and the poetic embellishments of Thucydides—the two Greeks are rightly acknowledged as the first true historians in the West. The era of recounting heroic deeds in epic poetry was over, and a new method of recording the past had begun.

of the accuracy of *The Histories* and called Herodotus "a father of lies."

Expressing a viewpoint

The Athenian writer Thucydides (c. 460–c. 400 BCE) also took a new approach to recording history. His

famous *History of the Peloponnesian War*,

written in 41 books, tells the story of the war between Athens and Sparta (see p.95). As well as recounting the events, Thucydides examined the long-term causes of the war and the moral issues it raised. A striking characteristic of his writing is the use of long speeches, not reproduced

Linear B script

This tablet is inscribed with early Greek writing known as "Linear B." It is thought to be a Bronze Age form of Greek used to record lists and inventories at Knossos.



"To preserve the memory of the past by **putting on record** [our own] astonishing achievements..."

ONE OF THE AIMS OF HERODOTUS SET OUT AT THE BEGINNING OF "THE HISTORIES," c.440 BCE

HOW WE KNOW

VIEW OF THE WORLD

This map, from a woodcut made in 1867, shows Herodotus's view of the world, based on the descriptions found in his writings, with Asia Minor and the Middle East at its center. Although he did not venture far in modern terms—he was unaware of northern Europe, for example—he included an extraordinary amount of detail about the places he did visit, (Egypt, Africa, Italy, Sicily, and other parts of the Mediterranean), including the length of rivers and sizes of continents. Much of this was previously unknown.

